

TRAVEL PLAN & ITINERARY

# Sianna's 2nd Birthday at Walt Disney World

*Thursday, August 13 – Monday, August 17, 2026*

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Orlando, Florida

Animal Kingdom • Magic Kingdom • Disney Springs

Prepared for a party of four — two parents, grandmother, and Sianna  
Birthday celebration: Saturday, August 15 at Magic Kingdom

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# 1. Trip at a Glance

|              |                                                                                                                 |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Travelers    | 4 total — you, your wife, your mother-in-law, and Sianna (turning 2 on Aug 15)                                  |
| Hotel        | Embassy Suites by Hilton Orlando Lake Buena Vista Resort, 8100 Lake St, Orlando FL 32836 · (407) 239-1144       |
| Hotel dates  | Check in Thu Aug 13 (4:00 PM) → check out Mon Aug 17 (11:00 AM)                                                 |
| Park tickets | 3 × Walt Disney World 2-Day, 2-Park ticket (1 park per day, <b>no Park Hopper</b> ), valid any 2 days Aug 13–16 |
| Park days    | Fri Aug 14 → Disney's Animal Kingdom · Sat Aug 15 → Magic Kingdom                                               |
| Free days    | Thu Aug 13 (arrival evening) and Sun Aug 16 (no park ticket left)                                               |

**Good news on tickets:** Sianna does not need a park ticket at all. Disney admits children **under age 3** free, and she'll be 2 for the entire trip. Your three adult tickets are all you need, and she doesn't need a Lightning Lane pass either — she just comes along.

## Flights as booked

### Outbound — Thursday, August 13 (American Airlines, Economy)

|          |                                                   |
|----------|---------------------------------------------------|
| 9:30 AM  | Depart LaGuardia (LGA), New York — AA <b>2027</b> |
| 12:03 PM | Arrive Charlotte Douglas (CLT)                    |
| 1:45 PM  | Depart Charlotte (CLT) — AA <b>1516</b>           |
| 3:31 PM  | Arrive Orlando International (MCO)                |

### Return — Monday, August 17 (Southwest Airlines)

|                  |                                       |
|------------------|---------------------------------------|
| 8:40 AM          | Depart Orlando (MCO) — WN <b>2603</b> |
| 10:40 AM (local) | Arrive Kansas City (MCI)              |
| 1:10 PM (local)  | Depart Kansas City (MCI)              |
| 4:55 PM          | Arrive LaGuardia (LGA)                |

The return is a long travel day with a roughly 2.5-hour layover in Kansas City. An 8:40 AM departure from MCO means leaving the hotel around 5:45 AM, so plan Sunday evening around an early night.

## Confirmed park hours and entertainment for your dates

| Date       | Park      | Hours                    | Key times                            |
|------------|-----------|--------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Thu Aug 13 | (no park) | Magic Kingdom 9 AM–10 PM | Arrival day — Disney Springs instead |

| Date       | Park           | Hours                                            | Key times                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|------------|----------------|--------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Fri Aug 14 | Animal Kingdom | 8:00 AM – 6:00/7:00 PM                           | Festival of the Lion King 10, 11, 12, 1, 2, 3, 4 · Winged Encounters 8:15, 9:15, 10:15, 11:15, 12:15 · Feathered Friends in Flight 10:45, 11:45, 1:45, 2:45, 3:45 · Finding Nemo 11, 12, 1, 2:30, 3:30, 4:30            |
| Sat Aug 15 | Magic Kingdom  | 8:00/9:00 AM – 11:00 PM                          | Mickey's Magical Friendship Faire 10:00, 11:10, 12:25, 1:40, 4:00 · Adventure Friends Cavalcade 11:05 · <b>Festival of Fantasy Parade 2:00 PM</b> · Flag Retreat 5:00 PM · <b>Happily Ever After fireworks 10:00 PM</b> |
| Sun Aug 16 | (no park)      | Animal Kingdom 8 AM–8 PM, water parks 10 AM–8 PM | Free day                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| Mon Aug 17 | (travel)       | —                                                | Depart MCO 8:40 AM                                                                                                                                                                                                      |

Two sources disagree slightly on opening and closing times (AllEars lists Magic Kingdom 9 AM–10 PM and Animal Kingdom 8 AM–6 PM; TouringPlans lists 8 AM–11 PM and 8 AM–7 PM). Plan for the earlier opening and confirm in the My Disney Experience app the week of the trip.

## The luckiest thing about your plan

**Friday, August 14 is a Mickey's Not-So-Scary Halloween Party night**, which means Magic Kingdom closes at 6:00 PM to regular ticket holders that day, with no Festival of Fantasy parade and no Happily Ever After fireworks. Saturday, August 15 is *not* a party night, so Magic Kingdom runs full hours with the 2:00 PM parade and 10:00 PM fireworks.

Your chosen order — Animal Kingdom on the 14th, Magic Kingdom on the 15th — is exactly right. Do not swap the days.

## 2. Do These Before You Fly

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Ordered by deadline. The first item is genuinely urgent and easy to miss.

### Verify Sianna has her own purchased seat on the August 17 return flight

US airlines permit lap-infant travel only for children **under 2 years old**. Sianna turns 2 on **August 15**, which puts her on either side of that line during this trip:

- **Outbound, Thursday Aug 13** — she is still 1. A lap-infant booking is fine.
- **Return, Monday Aug 17** — she is 2. Southwest requires her to occupy **her own purchased seat**.

If she was booked as a lap infant for the round trip, the return leg is non-compliant and you could be stopped at the gate in Orlando at 6:30 AM on a travel morning. That is the worst possible time to discover it.

**Action:** call Southwest at **1-800-435-9792**, confirm the Aug 17 booking has a paid seat for Sianna, and add one if it doesn't. Do this today — fares only go up, and the flight may fill.

While you're at it: if she has her own seat, bring an **FAA-approved car seat** for the plane. It's safer than a lap belt for a 2-year-old, she's far more likely to nap in a familiar seat, and you need a car seat in Orlando anyway (see the departure-day note in section 3).

### Book dining now

The 60-day reservation window is already open for all of your dates, so book today. Use the My Disney Experience app or call **(407) 939-3463** (407-WDW-DINE).

1. **Tusker House Restaurant**, Animal Kingdom — character breakfast with Mickey, Donald, Daisy, and Goofy in safari outfits. Target **8:00–9:00 AM on Fri Aug 14**. Roughly \$52/adult.
2. **The Crystal Palace**, Magic Kingdom — character buffet with Winnie the Pooh, Tigger, Piglet, and Eeyore. Target **11:00 AM–12:30 PM on Sat Aug 15**. Breakfast \$54/adult, lunch and dinner \$64/adult.

**Sianna eats free at both** — children under 3 eat from a parent's plate at Disney buffets at no charge.

Character *dining* is a much better bet than character *lines* at age 2. The characters come to your table, you're seated and air-conditioned, there's no 40-minute queue in the sun, and if she gets shy you can simply stay in your chair. Pooh and friends are also the single best character match for a 2-year-old.

### Order the birthday cake

Add a **Mickey Mouse Celebration Cake** (\$45 plus tax, feeds 4–6, choice of dark, milk, or white chocolate, "Happy Birthday" written on one ear) to the **Crystal Palace reservation on Aug 15**. Order it in the app when you book, or in person at the host podium at least 4 days ahead. Same-day requests are possible but stock is limited.

Backup or addition: **Amorette's Patisserie** at Disney Springs sells walk-up Petit Cakes, so you can pick one up on Aug 13 or Aug 16 and do a second candle moment in your suite. A \$6 birthday cupcake from Main Street Bakery works too — at 2, the candle is the whole event and the cake is incidental.

## Set up the app and link everything

Download **My Disney Experience**, create accounts, and link all three tickets, your hotel stay, and everyone in Family & Friends so one person can buy and manage Lightning Lane for the whole group. Do this before you travel — sorting it out at the gate in 92-degree heat with a toddler is miserable.

## Calendar these exact moments

| When                   | What                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Today                  | Call Southwest about Sianna's seat on the Aug 17 return                                                                                                                                        |
| Tue Aug 11, 7:00 AM ET | Lightning Lane Multi Pass goes on sale for your <b>Aug 14</b> Animal Kingdom day (off-site guests book 3 days ahead)                                                                           |
| Wed Aug 12, 7:00 AM ET | Lightning Lane Multi Pass goes on sale for your <b>Aug 15</b> Magic Kingdom day                                                                                                                |
| Fri Aug 14, 7:00 AM ET | Join the <b>Bluey's Wild World virtual queue</b> in the app. You do <i>not</i> need to be in the park. It sells out in seconds; a second drop at 10:00 AM requires being inside Animal Kingdom |
| ~Aug 11                | Call the hotel at (407) 239-1144 to confirm the current shuttle schedule                                                                                                                       |
| Sun Aug 16, evening    | Pre-book the 5:45 AM airport car for Monday                                                                                                                                                    |

## On Lightning Lane: buy it for Magic Kingdom, skip it for Animal Kingdom

Lightning Lane Multi Pass runs about **\$19–35 per person at Animal Kingdom** and **\$32–45 per person at Magic Kingdom**, priced dynamically. Off-site guests book 3 days out; Disney Resort guests get 7 days, which means the best Animal Kingdom slots are partly picked over before your window even opens.

- **Animal Kingdom: skip it.** The only attractions there with punishing lines are Avatar Flight of Passage (44") and Expedition Everest (44"), and nobody in your party is riding those with a 2-year-old along. Kilimanjaro Safaris and Na'vi River Journey are very manageable if you're there at opening.
- **Magic Kingdom: worth it** (roughly \$100–135 for three adults). Peter Pan's Flight, The Many Adventures of Winnie the Pooh, Under the Sea, Jungle Cruise, and the carousel-adjacent Fantasyland rides all build long standby lines, and they're all rides Sianna can do. A 2-year-old's patience is the scarcest resource on this trip, and this is the only thing money can buy that directly protects it.

## One booking caution

Mid-August is peak Atlantic hurricane season. Orlando's odds of a direct hit in any given week are low, but check your airline's and hotel's weather-waiver policies now so you know your options if a storm develops.

### 3. Day-by-Day Plan

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#### Thursday, August 13 — Arrival and a soft landing

| Time    | Plan                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|---------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 3:31 PM | Land at MCO. With bags and a toddler, budget until about 4:15 PM to get curbside                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 4:15 PM | Ground transport to the hotel, roughly 25–30 minutes. Uber/Lyft runs about \$40–55; Mears Connect shared shuttle is cheaper per person                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 5:00 PM | Check in (check-in opens at 4:00 PM). <b>Request a crib or pack-'n-play</b> — free for ages 2 and under, which still includes Sianna                                                                                                                                                                    |
| 5:30 PM | <b>Complimentary evening reception</b> — free drinks and snacks. Takes the pressure off dinner entirely                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| 6:15 PM | <b>Publix grocery run.</b> There's a Publix at Regency Village / Crossroads of Lake Buena Vista about half a mile away. Buy water, milk, fruit, snacks, and diapers. This one errand will save you well over \$100 across four days and is the difference between a smooth toddler trip and a rough one |
| 7:15 PM | <b>Hotel pool and kids' splash zone.</b> There's a complimentary dive-in movie most evenings. Let Sianna burn off the flight                                                                                                                                                                            |
| 8:30 PM | Early bedtime. Tomorrow starts at 6:15 AM                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

**Do not** try to squeeze in a park today. Your ticket is only 2 days and you need both of them for Aug 14 and 15. If everyone is somehow full of energy, an Uber to Disney Springs (about 10 minutes, \$12–15) for dinner and a stop at Amorette's is the one optional add.

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#### Friday, August 14 — Animal Kingdom

Animal Kingdom is the best park in Orlando for a 2-year-old, because most of what makes it great — the animals — has no height requirement, no queue, and nothing dark or loud. It's also the hottest park with the least midday shade, so treat it as a morning park and plan to be done by early afternoon.

| Time          | Plan                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 7:00 AM sharp | <b>Join the Bluey's Wild World virtual queue in the app.</b> Do it from the hotel room, from bed if you like. It goes in seconds                                                                                                                                                                              |
| 6:45–7:15 AM  | Complimentary made-to-order breakfast at the hotel (or grab-and-go if you booked Tusker House)                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| 7:20 AM       | Leave for the park. <b>Take an Uber/Lyft directly to Animal Kingdom</b> (about 15 minutes, \$15–20). The hotel shuttle does not run a direct Animal Kingdom route — you'd go to the TTC or EPCOT and transfer to a Disney bus, which costs you an hour                                                        |
| 8:00 AM       | Park opens. Walk straight past the Tree of Life to Africa and ride <b>Kilimanjaro Safaris first</b> . Do not detour. Animals are most active in the cool morning, and this is the single best thing in the park for a toddler — real giraffes and elephants at close range, no darkness, no drops, no waiting |

| Time     | Plan                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 8:45 AM  | <b>Gorilla Falls Exploration Trail</b> , right next door — shaded, stroller-friendly, gorillas and hippos at toddler eye level                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| 9:15 AM  | <b>Tusker House breakfast</b> in Harambe. Mickey, Donald, Daisy, and Goofy in safari gear come to your table. Air conditioning, sitting down, characters without a queue. A lovely birthday-eve celebration                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 10:30 AM | <b>Bluey's Wild World</b> , if you got a boarding group. The Wildlife Express Train station is right by Tusker House, so it's well placed. Two caveats: the full round trip runs <b>60–90 minutes for a 13-minute show</b> , and <b>strollers can't come into the show space</b> . It's pitched at ages 3 to 10, so a just-turned-2-year-old may enjoy Bluey and Bingo without following the games. If you don't get a boarding group, skip it without guilt |
| 12:00 PM | <b>Festival of the Lion King</b> (shows at 12:00 or 1:00). Air-conditioned, 30 minutes, huge puppets, live singing, no dark or scary passages. Reliably a toddler favorite, and you can hold her on your lap the whole time                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 12:45 PM | <b>Na'vi River Journey</b> in Pandora — a slow indoor boat ride through a glowing bioluminescent forest, no height requirement, no drops. Dim but not frightening, and only about 5 minutes                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| 1:30 PM  | Optional: <b>Maharajah Jungle Trek</b> (tigers) if energy holds, or <b>Discovery Island Trails</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| 2:00 PM  | <b>Leave</b> . Uber back to the hotel. Nap, pool, air conditioning. Don't push into the afternoon heat                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| 6:00 PM  | Evening reception, dinner near the hotel, easy night. Sianna's big day is tomorrow                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |

**Skip these with a 2-year-old:** *Zootopia: Better Zoogether!* in the Tree of Life theater is a dark 3D show with water spray, air blasts, and loud moments — it replaced the notoriously toddler-unfriendly *It's Tough to Be a Bug* and is gentler, but it's still dark and loud and it is not worth the risk of scaring her early in the day. *Finding Nemo: The Big Blue... and Beyond!* is an excellent 40-minute theater show and far too long at this age. *Kali River Rapids* (38"), *Expedition Everest* (44"), and *Avatar Flight of Passage* (44") are all height-gated well above her.

**What's gone since you may have last looked:** DinoLand U.S.A. closed permanently on February 2, 2026, to become the new Tropical Americas land in 2027. That means DINOSAUR, TriceraTop Spin, Restaurantosaurus, and **The Boneyard playground** are all gone. The Boneyard was the park's best toddler play space, so its absence genuinely changes this park for your age group. Expect construction walls along the east side.

## Saturday, August 15 — Magic Kingdom, Sianna's 2nd Birthday

This is the day. Magic Kingdom is open until 11:00 PM with the parade at 2:00 PM and fireworks at 10:00 PM, which gives you room for the only structure that really works with a 2-year-old in Florida in August: **a big morning, a real nap back at the hotel, and a fresh evening**. Do not attempt 13 straight hours.

A useful expectation to set now: at 2, the reliably magical things are the **parade**, the **carousel**, **Dumbo**, and the **splash pad** — not the headliner rides. The day is a success if she claps at the parade and gets a photo with Mickey. Everything past that is for the adults, which is fine, as long as you know that going in.



## MORNING — ROPE DROP FANTASYLAND

| Time     | Plan                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 6:45 AM  | Wake, hotel breakfast                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| 7:20 AM  | <b>Take the hotel's 7:20 AM Magic Kingdom shuttle to the TTC</b> — the one hotel shuttle run that's genuinely well timed. Then monorail or ferry across. Alternative: Uber to <b>Disney's Contemporary Resort</b> and walk the flat 10-minute path to the park entrance, skipping the TTC bottleneck entirely                                                                                                 |
| 8:00 AM  | Through the gates. <b>Go left to City Hall in Town Square first</b> and get Sianna a free <b>"It's My Birthday!" button</b> , plus "1st Visit" buttons for anyone who wants one. This takes 3 minutes and pays off all day — cast members and characters react to that button constantly, and unprompted extra magic (a free cupcake, a special sticker, front-row treatment at a show) happens because of it |
| 8:10 AM  | <b>Mickey Mouse at Town Square Theater</b> , 30 seconds from City Hall. The line is shortest at opening. Mickey plus the birthday button is <i>the</i> photo of this trip — get it before anyone is tired, hot, or overstimulated                                                                                                                                                                             |
| 8:30 AM  | Straight up Main Street to <b>Fantasyland</b> . Start with <b>it's a small world</b> — bright, gentle, slow, and the safest possible first ride at this age. Then <b>The Many Adventures of Winnie the Pooh</b> → <b>Peter Pan's Flight</b> (dark but gentle) → <b>Under the Sea: Journey of The Little Mermaid</b>                                                                                           |
| 9:45 AM  | <b>Prince Charming Regal Carrousel</b> , then <b>Dumbo the Flying Elephant</b> in Storybook Circus. These two are the highest-probability wins of the entire trip. Dumbo's queue includes an indoor air-conditioned play tent where you get a pager — a real gift on a hot morning                                                                                                                            |
| 10:15 AM | <b>Ariel's Grotto</b> and/or <b>Mickey's PhilharMagic</b> (air-conditioned, 12 minutes, 3D but gentle and funny)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| 10:45 AM | <b>Casey Jr. Splash 'N' Soak Station</b> in Storybook Circus — a splash play area. Bring a swim diaper and a full change of clothes and just let her go. In August this is worth more to a 2-year-old than any ride in the park                                                                                                                                                                               |

## MIDDAY — CAKE AND CHARACTERS

| Time     | Plan                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 11:30 AM | <b>The Crystal Palace with the Mickey Celebration Cake</b> . Pooh, Tigger, Piglet, and Eeyore come to the table; the cake arrives with the staff singing. This is the birthday centerpiece, and it happens indoors in air conditioning at the hottest part of the day. Tell your server it's her birthday the moment you sit down |
| 1:00 PM  | Optional: <b>Princess Fairytale Hall</b> in Fantasyland, or <b>Mirabel at Fairytale Garden</b> . The princesses are "face characters" who talk, which many 2-year-olds find much less startling than a full costumed head                                                                                                         |
| 2:00 PM  | <b>Disney Festival of Fantasy Parade</b> . Claim a curb spot on Main Street or in Frontierland 20 minutes early and hold her on your lap. Enormous floats, Maleficent breathing fire, every character at once. For a 2-year-old this will very likely be the best thing that happens all week                                     |
| 2:45 PM  | <b>Go back to the hotel</b> . Nap. Pool. Air conditioning. Yes, it costs you an hour of transit each way. Do it anyway — a 2-year-old who skips her nap in 92-degree heat will end your day for you at 4:00 PM, on her terms                                                                                                      |

## EVENING — THE GOOD PART

| Time    | Plan                                                                                                         |
|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 6:00 PM | Return to Magic Kingdom. Same-day re-entry to the same park is fine — you just can't hop to a different park |
| 6:30 PM | Dinner in the park. <b>Mobile order in the app</b> rather than queuing                                       |

| Time     | Plan                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 7:15 PM  | <b>Adventureland:</b> <i>Walt Disney's Enchanted Tiki Room</i> (air-conditioned, singing birds, 10 minutes, perfect at this age), <i>The Magic Carpets of Aladdin</i> , <i>Jungle Cruise</i>                                                                                                                                              |
| 8:00 PM  | <b>Tomorrowland:</b> the <i>Tomorrowland Transit Authority PeopleMover</i> is a 10-minute open-air ride with a breeze and almost no line — toddlers fall asleep on it constantly and adults get a rest. Then <i>Buzz Lightyear's Space Ranger Spin</i> (reopened April 2026, no height requirement) and <i>Monsters, Inc. Laugh Floor</i> |
| 9:15 PM  | Get into position for fireworks. <b>Put her ear protection on now</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| 10:00 PM | <b>Happily Ever After</b> — fireworks plus full castle projections, about 18 minutes                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| 10:20 PM | Head out                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

**Be honest with yourself about the 10:00 PM fireworks.** That is roughly three hours past a normal 2-year-old bedtime, at the end of a very long day, and the show is loud. She will not remember it. Three ways to play it, in the order I'd recommend them:

- 1. Watch from the beach or lawn at Disney's Contemporary Resort.** No crowd, no ticket needed, a lovely view straight across Seven Seas Lagoon, room for her to lie in the stroller, and your ride home is right there. You lose the castle projections and gain everything else. With a 2-year-old, this is the smart version.
- 2. Watch from inside the park, but don't fight for the hub.** The castle-forward hub is a crush by 9:00 PM, strollers get cleared out of it, and you'll be pinned there afterward. Stand further back near Casey's Corner or in the Plaza so you can walk out the second it ends.
- 3. Skip it and leave at 8:30.** A completely defensible choice. You'll be in bed by 10 and much better company on Sunday.

Whichever you choose: **bring toddler ear defenders.** The finale is genuinely loud, and the concussive booms are what frighten small children, not the lights. Best \$20 in your bag.

**Getting out after fireworks:** the monorail and ferry lines after a 10:00 PM show are brutal. With a stroller the best move is to **walk to the Contemporary Resort** (about 10 minutes on a flat, well-lit path) and get an Uber from that porte-cochère. Note that **the hotel shuttle has no Magic Kingdom return run**, so you're taking a rideshare regardless.

**One thing she's not old enough for:** Bibbidi Bobbidi Boutique inside Cinderella Castle does princess makeovers, but the minimum age is 3 and cast members enforce it strictly. Save it for a return trip — it's a genuinely lovely reason to come back when she's 4 or 5 and can sit still for an hour.

## A note on characters at age 2

This is the one thing most first-time toddler trips get wrong. Plenty of 2-year-olds who adore Mickey on television are frightened by a silent, six-foot, full-costume Mickey at close range. It's completely normal and it isn't a failure.

- Don't force it.** Let her watch other children go first from the safety of your arms. Disney's character performers are trained to read this instantly — they'll kneel, slow down, wave from a distance, or offer a fist bump instead of a hug.

- **"Face characters" are easier.** The princesses, Mirabel, Aladdin and Jasmine, and Belle all have visible human faces and can talk to her. Many toddlers who panic at Pooh are delighted by Cinderella.
- **Character meals are the gentlest possible introduction**, which is a large part of why Tusker House and Crystal Palace are the backbone of this plan. She stays in her own chair, on her own terms, and the character leaves after 30 seconds.
- **Take the photo anyway.** A shot of her burying her face in your shoulder while Tigger waves is a better family photograph in ten years than a posed one.

## Sunday, August 16 — Free Day

Your 2-day ticket is spent. Don't buy a third park day — after two big days in August heat, a third would be a slog, and you fly at 8:40 AM Monday.

**Recommended plan (low effort, high payoff):**

| Time    | Plan                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Morning | Sleep in. Long hotel breakfast. <b>Hotel pool and splash zone</b> until lunch. This is the day everyone recovers                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| 1:00 PM | <b>Disney's Animal Kingdom Lodge</b> (free, about 15 minutes by Uber). Walk into the Jambo House lobby and out to the savanna overlooks — giraffes, zebras, and ankole cattle grazing 30 feet away, no ticket required. For a 2-year-old who just did Animal Kingdom, this lands beautifully, and it's all at stroller pace. Lunch at The Mara      |
| 4:00 PM | <b>Disney Springs</b> . Free to enter, and the toddler-friendly bits are excellent: the <b>Marketplace Carousel</b> and <b>Marketplace Train Express</b> (a few dollars each), the splash fountains, the <b>LEGO Store</b> play tables and dragon, and <b>World of Disney</b> for the souvenir                                                      |
| 6:00 PM | Dinner at <b>T-REX Cafe</b> or <b>Rainforest Cafe</b> — full-size animatronic dinosaurs and a thunderstorm every 20 minutes. Both are loud, so at 2 this could go either way; ask for a table away from the biggest animatronics. Pick up a Petit Cake at <b>Amorette's</b> for a second candle moment and Gideon's Bakehouse cookies for the plane |
| 8:00 PM | Back to the hotel. <b>Pack tonight</b> . Lay out clothes and the stroller, and set aside bananas and snacks for the 5:45 AM departure — the hotel's free breakfast doesn't start early enough to help you                                                                                                                                           |

**If you'd rather do one more "wow" for Sianna** and you have a rental car, the best option in Central Florida for her exact age is **Peppa Pig Theme Park** in Winter Haven — a 4.5-acre park built specifically for ages 2 to 6, with six rides (only one has a height requirement, 36" for Daddy Pig's Roller Coaster), six playgrounds, a Muddy Puddles splash pad, and character shows. Tickets from about \$34 online, roughly half the gate price, and the park is cashless. Note that **she'll need her own ticket** — Peppa Pig charges from age 2, and she turns 2 the day before.

It's a 45–55 minute drive each way and opens at 10:00 AM, so it costs about two hours in the car. It is the most age-appropriate attraction in the region for her, and also a real trade against a rest day before a 5:45 AM wake-up. Your call.

**Other options, in rough order of fit:**

- **Typhoon Lagoon or Blizzard Beach** (both 10 AM–8 PM on the 16th) — Ketchakiddee Creek and Tike's Peak are dedicated toddler areas with zero-depth water. Requires separate tickets, and Sianna is free at under 3.

- **Orlando Science Center** — the KidsTown floor is superb for ages 2 to 4, entirely indoors and air-conditioned. About 30 minutes away.
  - **Gatorland** — cheap, quirky, with a "Gator Gully" splash park. About 30 minutes.
  - **SEA LIFE Orlando Aquarium** at ICON Park — indoor, short, and easy on a mother-in-law's feet.
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## Monday, August 17 — Departure

| Time    | Plan                                                       |
|---------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5:15 AM | Wake                                                       |
| 5:45 AM | Car to MCO (pre-booked the night before). About 30 minutes |
| 6:20 AM | Arrive MCO. Southwest bag drop, then security              |
| 8:40 AM | Depart for Kansas City                                     |

**Car seat note:** Florida law requires a child restraint for children 3 and under, and rideshare drivers do not carry them. Either bring a lightweight travel car seat — you'll want it for every Uber all week and on the plane — or book a private transfer that supplies one, and confirm the car seat explicitly when you book.

**Gate-check the stroller.** You can use it right up to the aircraft door at both MCO and MCI, and it'll be waiting at the door on arrival.

## 4. What Sianna Can Actually Ride

Good news: almost everything a 2-year-old wants to do has no height requirement. A typical 2-year-old is around **33 to 35 inches**, so realistically she clears none of the height-gated rides except possibly Tomorrowland Speedway. Measure her against a wall before you go — height is checked with shoes on at the entrance and re-checked at boarding.

### Magic Kingdom — no height requirement

**Start here at age 2:** *it's a small world* · *Prince Charming Regal Carrousel* · *Dumbo the Flying Elephant* · *The Many Adventures of Winnie the Pooh* · *Walt Disney's Enchanted Tiki Room* · *Casey Jr. Splash 'N' Soak Station* · *Tomorrowland Transit Authority PeopleMover* · *The Magic Carpets of Aladdin*

**Also fine, slightly darker or busier:** *Peter Pan's Flight* · *Under the Sea: Journey of The Little Mermaid* · *Mickey's PhilharMagic* · *Buzz Lightyear's Space Ranger Spin* · *Jungle Cruise* · *Monsters, Inc. Laugh Floor* · *Astro Orbiter* · *Country Bear Musical Jamboree* · *The Hall of Presidents* (dark and long — the best accidental nap in the park) · *Walt Disney World Railroad* (shuttle route only, see section 8) · *Main Street Vehicles* (mornings) · *Enchanted Tales with Belle*

**Approach with caution at 2:** *Pirates of the Caribbean* is dark with cannon fire and one small drop. *Haunted Mansion* has no height limit but is genuinely spooky. *Mad Tea Party* spins hard. *Swiss Family Treehouse* is all stairs with no stroller access.

### Magic Kingdom — height requirements (use Rider Switch)

| Attraction                    | Minimum             | Realistic at 2?          |
|-------------------------------|---------------------|--------------------------|
| Tomorrowland Speedway         | 32" (with an adult) | Borderline — measure her |
| The Barnstormer               | 35"                 | Unlikely                 |
| Seven Dwarfs Mine Train       | 38"                 | No                       |
| Big Thunder Mountain Railroad | 40"                 | No                       |
| Tiana's Bayou Adventure       | 40"                 | No                       |
| Space Mountain                | 44"                 | No                       |
| TRON Lightcycle / Run         | 48"                 | No                       |

### Animal Kingdom — no height requirement

*Kilimanjaro Safaris* · *Na'vi River Journey* · *Gorilla Falls Exploration Trail* · *Maharajah Jungle Trek* · *Discovery Island Trails* · *Festival of the Lion King* · *Feathered Friends in Flight!* · *Winged Encounters* · *Bluey's Wild World and Wildlife Express Train* (virtual queue required) · *The Animation Experience*

Not recommended at 2 despite having no height limit: *Zootopia: Better Zoogether!* (dark 3D with water and air effects) and *Finding Nemo: The Big Blue... and Beyond!* (40 minutes).

## Animal Kingdom — height requirements

Kali River Rapids 38" · Expedition Everest 44" · Avatar Flight of Passage 44"

## How Rider Switch works

With three adults and one toddler, this is how the grown-ups still ride the big stuff. Bring your **whole group, including Sianna**, to the attraction entrance and tell the cast member you want Rider Switch. They'll split you into Party A (rides first, via the standby queue) and Party B (waits outside with Sianna — a maximum of two people ride on the second turn). They scan Party B's tickets and tell you where to return. When Party A finishes, Party B enters through the Lightning Lane return without waiting again. If Party B is only one person, someone from Party A can re-ride with them.

The cast member must physically see the child who isn't riding, so don't send one person ahead to set it up.

## 5. Where to Eat

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Book these two now:

| Restaurant         | Where                  | When                          | Why                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|--------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Tusker House       | Animal Kingdom, Africa | Fri Aug 14, 8:00–9:00 AM      | Mickey, Donald, Daisy, Goofy in safari outfits. African-inspired buffet plus Mickey waffles and mac-and-cheese for kids. Widely considered the best-value character meal at Disney World and usually the easiest to book |
| The Crystal Palace | Magic Kingdom, the hub | Sat Aug 15, 11:00 AM–12:30 PM | Winnie the Pooh, Tigger, Piglet, Eeyore. The birthday cake moment. Plan on 90 minutes to see all four characters                                                                                                         |

Sianna eats free at both.

Worth knowing:

- **Mobile order everything else.** Quick service lines at both parks are long at peak times and the app lets you skip them. Budget \$18–22 per adult per quick service meal.
- **Free ice water** at any quick service counter — just ask. Refill bottles constantly.
- **You can bring your own food** into the parks. No glass containers and no loose ice, but a cooler bag of snacks, fruit, and sandwiches is allowed and saves real money with a toddler. Bring her usual snacks; a 2-year-old in a strange place will often eat only what she recognizes.
- **Skip Cinderella's Royal Table.** At \$70+ per person it's the most expensive way to meet princesses, and at 2 the value is close to zero.
- **A "Happy Birthday" cupcake** runs about \$6 at Main Street Bakery or Sleepy Hollow — a cheap second celebration.

## 6. Getting Around

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### The hotel shuttle: useful for exactly one thing

Your hotel runs a free scheduled shuttle (operated by Platinum Transportation). The most recently published schedule looks like this — **call (407) 239-1144 to confirm before you rely on it**, since the version online dates from May 2025:

**Departing the hotel:** 7:20 AM Magic Kingdom (drops at the TTC) · 8:45 AM EPCOT · 10:40 AM EPCOT · 11:35 AM Hollywood Studios · 5:15 PM Disney Springs

**Returning:** 4:15 PM and 7:50 PM Hollywood Studios · 10:15 PM and 10:30 PM EPCOT · 11:30 PM Disney Springs

Three things this tells you:

1. **The 7:20 AM Magic Kingdom run is excellent** — take it on Aug 15.
2. **There is no direct Animal Kingdom departure and no Magic Kingdom return.** The workaround is to ride to the TTC or EPCOT and transfer to Disney's own buses and monorails, which are free and continuous but add 30–60 minutes each way. On Aug 14, and on the night of Aug 15, just take an Uber.
3. **Only single umbrella-style strollers are allowed on the shuttle.** No wide strollers, no doubles, no wagons.

### On strollers, since she'll live in one

At 2 she'll be in the stroller most of every day, so this decision matters more than it looks. You want something that is **narrow enough for the hotel shuttle** (single umbrella style), **reclines far enough for real in-park napping**, and has **a deep sun canopy**. A stroller she'll actually sleep in is worth more to this trip than Lightning Lane. Add a clip-on fan and a rain cover.

Disney rents strollers in-park for about \$15/day, but they don't recline and you can't take them out of the park, so they're a poor fit here.

### What to expect from rideshare

Roughly \$15–25 each way between the hotel and any Disney park, and \$40–55 to or from MCO. Two specifics:

- **For Magic Kingdom, rideshare drops at the TTC**, not the park gate, so you still need the monorail or ferry. Getting dropped at **Disney's Contemporary Resort** instead lets you walk straight in, and it's the fastest way both in and out.
- **Bring your own car seat.** Florida requires a restraint at this age and drivers don't carry them.

### Not eligible: Early Theme Park Entry

Disney Resort hotels and about 15 select partner hotels get into the parks 30 minutes early. **Embassy Suites Orlando Lake Buena Vista is not on that list**, despite being a Disney Good Neighbor hotel and despite several nearby Hilton properties qualifying. Plan on regular opening times. This is also why your Lightning Lane window



is 3 days out rather than 7.

## 7. Surviving August in Orlando With a 2-Year-Old

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Mid-August is the hottest, wettest part of the Orlando year: **average highs of 91–92°F, lows around 75°F, humidity near 74%**, and a heat index that regularly clears 100°F. There are thunderstorms on about **18 days of the month**, almost always in the afternoon, and roughly a 60–67% chance of a wet day on any given date. Sunrise is around 6:55 AM and sunset around **8:05 PM**.

That climate dictates the entire shape of these plans:

- **Front-load every day.** Everything you actually care about happens between park opening and noon.
- **Treat the nap as fixed, not optional.** From roughly 1:00 to 5:00 PM, be at the pool or asleep. This isn't laziness; at 2 it's the difference between a good trip and a series of meltdowns.
- **Storms usually pass in 30–45 minutes.** Pack ponchos, not umbrellas — umbrellas are useless in crowds and Disney marks ponchos up heavily. Keep an indoor backup ready for every afternoon: Hall of Presidents, Mickey's PhilharMagic, Enchanted Tiki Room, and the Laugh Floor are all air-conditioned and near one another.
- **Lightning stops outdoor entertainment.** Parades and fireworks can be cancelled with no notice.
- **Watch her, not the thermometer.** Toddlers overheat faster than adults and can't tell you they're doing it. Flushed cheeks, unusual quiet, or refusing a drink all mean get inside now.

### Pack list

- **Compact single umbrella stroller that reclines** (required for the hotel shuttle) plus a clip-on fan and a rain cover
- **Toddler ear defenders** — non-negotiable if you're doing the 10:00 PM fireworks
- Ponchos for all four
- **Swim diapers, water shoes, and two full changes of clothes** for Casey Jr. Splash 'N' Soak
- Refillable water bottles, cooling towels, a misting spray bottle
- Sunscreen, wide sun hat, UPF long-sleeve shirt — she'll get more sun in a stroller than you'd think
- Diapers, wipes, and her usual snacks from the Publix run
- **Portable phone battery.** The My Disney Experience app annihilates a phone battery, and your tickets, Lightning Lane, and mobile orders all live inside it
- **Travel car seat** for rideshares and the plane
- A birthday outfit or Minnie ears — visible birthday cues get reactions all day
- Her comfort object. Whatever it is, bring two if you can

### Baby Care Centers

Both parks have free air-conditioned Baby Care Centers with changing tables, nursing areas, a microwave, and basic supplies for sale. Magic Kingdom's is at the top of Main Street, U.S.A. near First Aid; Animal Kingdom's is on Discovery Island. Confirm exact locations in the app. These are the two best places in either park to reset a

hot, overtired 2-year-old, and knowing where they are before you need one is worth a lot.

## 8. What's Closed or Changed in August 2026

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### Magic Kingdom

- **Walt Disney's Carousel of Progress** — closed since July 6, 2026, reopening 2027. A real loss, since it was a 21-minute air-conditioned sit-down.
- **Walt Disney World Railroad** — running as a shuttle between the Main Street and Fantasyland stations only. Frontierland station is closed.
- **Rivers of America, Tom Sawyer Island, and the Liberty Belle Riverboat** — permanently gone as of July 2025.
- **Villains Land and Piston Peak (Cars)** — the largest expansion in Magic Kingdom history is under construction behind Big Thunder Mountain and Haunted Mansion. Expect construction walls in Frontierland; neither land opens for years.
- **Pete's Silly Sideshow** (closed January 2026) and **Big Top Souvenirs** (closed February 2026) in Storybook Circus. Pete's is where Minnie, Donald, Daisy, and Goofy normally meet, so that meet-and-greet may be unavailable — check the app, since some guides still list it.
- **The Diamond Horseshoe, Frontierland Shootin' Arcade, Big Al, and Westward Ho** are all closed.
- Good news: **Big Thunder Mountain reopened** May 2026, and **Buzz Lightyear's Space Ranger Spin reopened** April 2026.

### Animal Kingdom

- **All of DinoLand U.S.A. closed permanently on February 2, 2026** — DINOSAUR, TriceraTop Spin, The Boneyard, Restaurantosaurus, Chester & Hester's, Donald's Dino Bash. It becomes Tropical Americas (an Encanto dark ride, an Indiana Jones ride, and a carousel) in 2027. The park has noticeably fewer rides than usual right now, and losing The Boneyard hurts most for your age group.
- **It's Tough to Be a Bug** was replaced by **Zootopia: Better Zoogether!** in November 2025.
- **New: Bluey's Wild World** at Conservation Station opened May 26, 2026. The virtual queue now also gates the Wildlife Express Train and the Conservation Station animal-care experiences.

## 9. Rough Budget Beyond What's Already Paid

Flights, hotel, and the three 2-day tickets are booked. Here's what else to expect.

| Item                                                                  | Estimate                |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|
| Sianna's park tickets                                                 | \$0 — free under age 3  |
| Southwest seat for Sianna on the Aug 17 return, if not already booked | \$150–350               |
| Lightning Lane Multi Pass, Magic Kingdom, 3 adults                    | \$100–135               |
| Lightning Lane, Animal Kingdom                                        | \$0 — recommended skip  |
| Tusker House breakfast, 3 adults                                      | ~\$170 with tax and tip |
| Crystal Palace lunch, 3 adults                                        | ~\$215 with tax and tip |
| Mickey Mouse Celebration Cake                                         | \$45 + tax              |
| Quick service meals and snacks                                        | \$250–350               |
| Rideshare: airport round trip plus park days                          | \$200–280               |
| Groceries (Publix run)                                                | \$60–90                 |
| Souvenirs, PhotoPass, birthday extras                                 | \$150–400               |
| Peppa Pig Theme Park, optional (3 adults + 1 child + parking)         | \$160–190               |
| Likely total                                                          | roughly \$1,200–2,100   |

The range is wide almost entirely because of one line: whether you still need to buy Sianna a seat for the return flight. Everything else is predictable. Prices are dynamic and current as of late July 2026 — verify before you commit.

# 10. Quick Reference

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## Phone numbers

|                               |                |
|-------------------------------|----------------|
| Southwest Airlines            | 1-800-435-9792 |
| Disney tickets and general    | (407) 939-5277 |
| Disney dining reservations    | (407) 939-3463 |
| Embassy Suites LBV front desk | (407) 239-1144 |

## The five things that matter most

1. **Confirm Sianna has her own purchased seat on the August 17 return flight.** She turns 2 on the 15th, and lap-infant travel ends at 2. This is the one item on the list that can stop you at a gate.
2. **Book Tusker House and Crystal Palace today,** and add the Mickey cake to the Crystal Palace reservation.
3. **Set a 7:00 AM alarm for August 14** for the Bluey virtual queue, and 7:00 AM alarms for August 11 and 12 for Lightning Lane.
4. **Get the free birthday button at City Hall within five minutes of entering Magic Kingdom.** It shapes the entire day.
5. **Protect the nap on both park days.** Every good toddler day at Disney World in August is really two short days with a nap in the middle.

**And the one detail nobody tells you:** tell every single cast member and every character that it's her birthday. Say it out loud, every time. That's the actual mechanism behind all the "Disney magic" stories — the people who work there want to make a fuss, and they need to be told.

Happy 2nd birthday, Sianna.

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*Compiled July 29, 2026. Park hours, showtimes, prices, and closures were verified against AllEars, TouringPlans, Disney's official pages, and the hotel's published shuttle schedule as of this date, but Disney changes all of these without notice. Re-check hours, showtimes, and the Not-So-Scary party calendar in the My Disney Experience app the week you travel.*